

SI-MI: Social Identity Matters in Mentoring

Session 1: Orientation

Guiding question: What experiences have shaped how I think about mentoring?

Overview: This opening session introduces the SI-MI course and begins building the trust needed for meaningful learning together. Participants will get to know one another, reflect on their own mentoring experiences, and establish shared expectations for dialogue. The session is designed to create a supportive learning community and to frame culturally responsive mentoring as an ongoing practice.

Objectives:

- Understand the overall purpose, structure, and expectations of the course
- Begin building community with other participants through introductions and shared reflection.
- Reflect on positive and negative mentoring experiences as a foundation for later sessions.

Before the Session: These materials will help orient you to the course and prepare you to reflect on your own mentoring experiences.

- Complete the anonymous [pre-assessment survey](#)
- Complete the [participant intake form](#)
- Read the [community guidelines](#)
- Reflect on your past mentoring experiences (both positive and negative)
- Think about strategies mentors use to support mentees
- Reflect on the impact mentors have had on you or others

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will include introductions, an overview of the course structure, a discussion of community guidelines, and guided conversations about mentoring experiences. Participants should expect a mix of full-group discussion and small-group breakout conversations.

Takeaways: After this week, you should be able to:

- Recognize how identity shapes mentoring relationships
- Identify ways intersectionality affects mentee experiences
- Apply an identity-aware lens when mentoring

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Session 2: Identity and Its Intersections

Guiding question: How do my identities influence the way I mentor or am mentored?

Overview: This session explores how identity and intersectionality shape experiences in STEM and mentoring relationships. Participants will reflect on their own identities, consider how systems of privilege and marginalization operate, and examine how intersecting identities can influence what mentees experience in academic settings.

Objectives:

- Define identity and intersectionality in the context of mentoring and STEM.
- Reflect on how personal identities and biases shape mentoring relationships.
- Recognize how intersecting identities can create distinct opportunities and challenges for mentees.

Before the Session: Complete the assigned pre-work and come ready to reflect on identity, privilege, and intersectionality. Be prepared to connect the ideas from the pre-work to your own experiences in STEM and to mentoring scenarios.

- **Complete:** [The Academic Wheel of Privilege](#) activity
- **Watch:** [TED Talk - The Urgency of Intersectionality](#) by Kimberlé Crenshaw
- **Read:** [15 Examples of Intersectionality](#)

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will combine individual reflection, breakout conversations, and larger group discussion. Participants will explore how identity influences participation in STEM and will apply an intersectional lens to broad mentoring case examples.

Takeaways: After this week, you should be able to:

- Recognize how identity and intersectionality influence experiences in mentoring and STEM
- Reflect on how your own identities and biases shape mentoring relationships
- Apply an intersectional perspective when considering mentee experiences and mentoring practices

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Session 3: Engaging in Empathic Conversations

Guiding question: How can mentors engage in difficult or vulnerable conversations with empathy while avoiding assumptions and maintaining trust?

Overview: This session focuses on how mentors can approach vulnerable or difficult conversations with empathy, care, and attention. Participants will consider the risks of making assumptions about mentees and will explore strategies that support more thoughtful, responsive communication. The emphasis is on building mentoring relationships that allow for honesty, trust, and mutual learning.

Objectives:

- Recognize the importance of empathy in difficult mentoring conversations.
- Identify personal or structural barriers that can make these conversations harder to initiate or sustain.
- Explore practical approaches that can strengthen communication across differences.

Before the Session: Complete the assigned listening and reading materials, including one of the selected articles. Come prepared to share a few key takeaways and practical ideas from the pre-work.

- **Sign Up:** For [ONE article](#) to read
- **Listen:** [Dare to Lead Podcast - Aiko Bethea on Inclusivity at Work](#) (30:15 - 41:30). [[Transcript](#)]
- **Read your chosen article:**
 - 1) [Martinez-Cola \(2020\)](#). 2) [Benishek et al. \(2004\)](#). 3) [Tanner & Allen \(2007\)](#).
- **Write:** 1-3 takeaways from the readings/podcast and 3-5 concrete actions recommended in the reading you chose
- **Reflect:**
 - What did you notice about the differences between the on-ramps and off-ramps in the role play? How does the identity of both people affect the likelihood of an “off-ramp” during the role-play?
 - Reflect on past vulnerable conversations you may have had as a mentor or mentee. Was the conversation handled with attention and empathy?

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will include small-group reflection, discussion of key ideas from the pre-work, and conversation about strategies for engaging in empathic mentoring. Participants should expect opportunities to connect the session content to their own mentoring practice.

Takeaways:

- Empathy in mentoring requires active listening, curiosity, and a willingness to sit with discomfort. Assumptions (especially those shaped by identity or bias) can undermine trust and communication.
- Difficult conversations are not one-time events but part of ongoing relationship-building.
- Practical strategies (i.e., open ended questions, reflection) can strengthen communication across differences.

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Session 4: Racialized Experiences in STEM

Guiding question: How can mentors understand and respond to racialized experiences in STEM while recognizing the limits of individual mentoring within systemic inequities?

Overview: This session examines how racism and other forms of marginalization shape experiences in STEM, especially for Black, Indigenous, and other people of color. Participants will explore these experiences as systemic rather than purely interpersonal issues and will consider what culturally aware mentoring can and cannot do within larger structures of inequity.

Objectives:

- Increase understanding of racialized experiences and barriers in STEM.
- Distinguish between systemic change and individual mentoring action.
- Reflect on the role of culturally aware mentoring within broader institutional inequities.

Before the Session: Complete the assigned article, podcast, and reflection before the session. Be prepared to think critically about the limits of mentoring, the value of culturally aware practice, and the difference between individual support and systemic change.

- **Read:** Nature Geoscience - [Scientists from Historically Excluded Groups Face a Hostile Obstacle Course](#)
- **Listen:** The Pitt Pulse Podcast - [Introduction to Racism in STEM with Dr. Ebony McGee](#) (31 min)
- **Reflect:**
 - Did the materials bring up any racialized experiences you have witnessed or lived? If so, how did this experience feel?
 - In the podcast, Dr. McGee states that mentoring programs “cannot dismantle 400 years of structural racism in society.” With that in mind, consider the following questions:
 - Is the work we are doing in this mentor training transformative?
 - If not, what purpose does it serve? What issues doesn't it solve?
 - What does being a culturally aware mentor do for mentees in your sphere of influence?

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will include guided reflection, group discussion, and opportunities to process emotional and practical responses to racialized experiences in academia. Participants should expect a thoughtful conversation that links structural realities to mentoring practice.

Takeaways:

- Racialized experiences in STEM are shaped by systemic inequities, not just individual interactions.
- Mentors play an important supportive role but cannot replace structural change.
- Acknowledging racism directly is more supportive than minimizing or avoiding it.

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Session 5: Color-Evasive Practices

Guiding question: How do color-evasive practices show up in mentoring, and how can mentors move toward more race-conscious and accountable approaches?

Overview: This session explores color-evasive language and practices and how they can obscure or minimize racial realities in academic settings. Participants will consider how these patterns show up in mentoring and will reflect on how more race-conscious, responsive approaches can better support students of color.

Objectives:

- Identify examples of color-evasive language, behavior, and assumptions.
- Understand how these practices can affect mentees and perpetuate inequity.
- Reflect on how mentoring responses can move from avoidance toward greater racial awareness and accountability.

Before the Session: Complete the assigned videos and reflection exercise before the session. Come ready to discuss how common statements or assumptions can overlook racial context and how those patterns may affect mentoring.

- **Watch:** TED Talk: [Color Blind or Color Brave?](#) by Mellody Hobson
 - **Note:** Since 2014, the ableist term “color blind” has been replaced by “color evasive.”
- **Watch:** [Color Evasiveness](#) by Angela Davis
- **Reflect:**
 - Consider the following statements. How does each statement lack a racial awareness lens? What are the potential effects of these statements on students of color? For each statement, what situation is more likely to be true?
 - **Statement A:** “I think if students of color just felt more confident and asked for help, they would be fine.”
 - **Statement B:** “In some communities, families just don't have the same love of science.”
 - **Statement C:** “It's not racial, it's about students who are from low-income schools that are underprepared.”

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will include group discussion, breakout conversations, and broad application of the week's ideas to mentoring contexts. Participants should expect to analyze examples, reflect on their own practice, and consider how to respond more thoughtfully in racially charged situations.

Takeaways:

- Color-evasive language can unintentionally dismiss or obscure mentees' lived experiences.
- Avoiding conversations about race can reinforce inequities rather than prevent harm
- Becoming more race-conscious requires reflection, discomfort, and intentional practice.

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Session 6: From Deficit- to Asset-Based Mentoring

Guiding question: How can mentors shift from deficit-based assumptions to recognizing and building on the strengths and assets mentees bring?

Overview: This session focuses on shifting from deficit-based assumptions to asset-based mentoring approaches, particularly when working with students of color. Participants will explore how mentors can better recognize strengths, forms of knowledge, and sources of resilience that may be overlooked in academic settings. The session emphasizes mentoring practices that affirm and build on what mentees already bring.

Objectives:

- Differentiate deficit-based and asset-based approaches to mentoring.
- Recognize strengths and forms of cultural wealth that mentees bring to academic environments.
- Consider how an asset-based perspective can reshape mentoring practice.

Before the Session: Complete the assigned readings and reflection before the session. Be prepared to think about how mentors can move beyond deficit narratives and more intentionally recognize, affirm, and support the assets of students of color.

- **Read:** [From Deficits to Possibilities](#) by Beronda L. Montgomery
- **Read:** [Whose Culture has Capital?](#) By Tara J. Yosso
 - Starting at P. 77 (I. Aspirational Capital) and ending on P.81 before the Discussion section
- **Reflect:**
 - How does the analogy of the relationship between humans and plants shift or deepen your understanding of what it means to support students?
 - What strengths or assets can be observed in students of color that may be overlooked when viewed through a deficit lens?

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will include reflection, group discussion, and collaborative application of strengths-based mentoring ideas. Participants should expect to explore broad examples, connect the readings to mentoring practice, and consider concrete ways to support mentees through an asset-based lens.

Takeaways:

- Deficit-based thinking limits how mentors perceive and support mentees.
- Asset-based mentoring highlights strengths, resilience, and forms of cultural wealth.
- Mentors can actively reframe narratives to focus on capability rather than lack.

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Session 7: Embodying Culturally Responsive Mentorship

Guiding question: How can mentors integrate culturally responsive principles into their ongoing practice and real-world mentoring situations?

Overview: This closing session brings together the major themes of the course and focuses on applying them in mentoring practice. Participants will reflect on what they have learned across the series, consider how culturally responsive principles can shape mentoring plans, and practice responding to mentoring situations using the skills developed throughout the course.

Objectives:

- Synthesize key ideas from across the course.
- Apply culturally responsive mentoring principles to broad mentoring situations.
- Reflect on personal takeaways and next steps for mentoring practice.

Before the Session: Review the assigned mentoring plans, complete the reflection questions, and prepare for a brief role-play activity. Come ready to identify strengths, areas for improvement, and course concepts that can inform more culturally responsive mentoring.

- **Review:** [Role-play scenarios](#)
- **Sign up:** [For one role-play scenario to act out in this live session](#)
- **Read:**
 - [Wilson Research Assistant Guidelines](#)
 - [McMahon Mentor-Mentee Contract](#)
- **Reflect:**
 - What are the positive elements of each mentoring plan?
 - What aspects of each mentoring plan need improvement?
 - How can each document be adjusted to be more culturally responsive?
 - Which lessons or skills from our course are present in each document? Which are missing?

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will include discussion of the pre-work, collaborative preparation for role-play, active role-play practice, and closing reflection. Participants should expect an applied, interactive session that invites them to integrate ideas from the full course and identify what they will carry forward.

Takeaways:

- Culturally responsive mentoring is an ongoing, reflective practice, not a fixed skill set.
- Applying course concepts requires intentionality, flexibility, and continued learning.